

FORMULA 1 FLASH

The world's most elite motor-racing code, Formula 1 mixes high-finance, high-technology and the high life.

■ This is the 58th year of the F1 World Championships and the 2008 season will run from March to November over 18 races.

■ The cost of staging an F1 race is in the region of \$300m; hosts' rights fees start at \$16m.

■ Team budgets per season vary from Force India's \$120m up to Ferrari's estimated \$400m-500m.

■ It cost Bahrain \$150m to build their F1 Grand Prix circuit while Shanghai spent \$450m.

■ The F1 circuit is a glamouratti magnet wherever it goes and gives team owners like Mallya unprecedented global mileage.

Indian F1 race is not on the calendar. It appears that the buzz may have been created but there is still some room left for race organisers to slip through.

The idea of a home F1 GP is a seductive one for it promises to bring this most glitzy and glamorous of sports up close and into the neighbourhood. But the closest an average racing junkie will get to the bling will be through binoculars from a public stand. Because F1 is an exclusive sport—exclusive as in about exclusion.

Setting out its stall in this zone where the fan seeks proximity to the manic men in their magnificent machines is A1GP. Clare insists, "We can't be compared to F1, we're in a different market. A1GP is relevant to markets where F1 is still seen as too elitist." A1GP reaches out to the same set of racing fans using a very different sales pitch. It calls itself 'the World Cup of motorsport' and the bait is nationality, accessibility and affordability (*see box*). As of the 2008-2009 season, legendary

Italian automotive giants Ferrari will be supplying the race cars to A1GP for six years, a development which will give the series much higher street cred.

This season A1GP has 22 cars competing over 10 races. Clare believes an ideal grid is 25 cars competing in 12-14 races. This is where India comes in. Talks about an Indian A1GP race have been on for 18 months, and A1Team India CEO Andaleep Sehgal said possible venues are street circuits in Faridabad, Jaipur or Goa. A1GP management has also noticed the response of the Indian diaspora to the team. In Taupo, New Zealand, an Indian restaurant-owner hauled meals over for Karthikeyan & Co while in Sydney, Indian fans matched Brazilians for volume.

Clare says in a few years time the Indian A1GP team should be "all" Indian including engineers and mechanics. Force India F1's closest identification with India though is through its name and marketing blitz at home. Mallya's ambition—to get a Force India car on the podium during the 2010 Indian GP—does not necessarily include an Indian driver. This season Italian Giancarlo Fisichella and German Adrian Sutil are steering the Force India car, the modestly-named VJM-1. Mallya had explained, "Experience and ability to assist the engineering team was a necessary requisite for our drivers. No Indian driver fits the bill."

Pre-season talks between Indian firm Spice Energy and struggling Japanese F1 team Super Aguri, however, broke down over the very issue. Spice Energy made an Indian driver a precondition to buying out Super Aguri. "No argument against having an Indian driver would satisfy us," said Sehgal.

Either way, for Chandhok this is the best time to be a young Indian driver. "My dream has been to drive and be successful in F1. The fact that we have a team in F1 and a race imminent, makes it seem more achievable."

Chandhok says Indian motorsport needs it all: a home GP, an Indian team in F1, more national events at the junior entry level. "We used to be oddball. Now people want to know about our motorsport. They ask Narain and me when India's going to have an F1 race."

An F1 GP might become a pitstop in the race for India where the spoils for the winner will be far, far bigger. ■

MASCOT: Karthikeyan's win in China galvanised A1GP Team India

